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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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The Classificatory Extension of Extra-clan Kinship

In keeping with the principles of lineage structure, a man visualizes his relationship with his mother's patrilineal kin as having three degrees. There is, firstly, his bond with his 'true *ah(ə)b* (*ah(ə)b ni yɔlmɔŋ(ə)r*)'—his mother's full (*soog*) brother, if she has one, or her oldest paternal half (*sunz(ə)*) brother. This is the man who will sacrifice on his sister's son's behalf (if *his* father is dead). Apart from this there is no distinction between the 'true *ah(ə)b*' and his brothers of the same nuclear lineage. The next level is that of the mother's brother's *dug*, his inner or at most medial lineage. A sister's son describes this *dug* collectively as his *ah(ə)b yiri*, or, by contraposition with the clan, as his *ah(ə)b dug*. Like any member of this inner lineage he distinguishes between its members in accordance with the rules of classificatory kinship. That is, the men whom his *ah(ə)b* calls 'father' he calls 'grandfather', and he jokes with them; the men and women whom his *ah(ə)b* calls siblings he calls *ah(ə)b* or mother; and he describes those whom his *ah(ə)b* calls his children as brothers and sisters. He may not marry a daughter of this inner lineage, and if he has sexual relations with one it is as disgraceful as if she were his close agnatic sister. He may not court a widow of any man of this inner lineage whom he calls *ah(ə)b*, and if he seduces the wife of such a man it is incest. He may in theory court the widow of a member of this *dug* whom his mother's brother calls 'son' and whom he, therefore, regards as a sort of brother.

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Finally, there is the level of his mother's brother's clan beyond the range of his inner lineage. Again the rules of classificatory kinship in the clan context apply. Beyond the range of his mother's brother's inner lineage a man does not distinguish between members of his mother's brother's lineage (his *ah(ə)b*

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yid (m) by generation. He can marry a daughter of the clan, or court a widow of any man of the clan, at this range.

Reciprocally, a man calls a child of a daughter of his inner lineage 'an *ah(ə)ŋ* of our *dug* (*ti dug ah(ə)ŋ*)', and a child of a daughter of a different inner lineage of the clan 'an *ah(ə)ŋ* of our lineage (or clan) (*ti yir ah(ə)ŋ*)'. There are a number of ritual ceremonies at which all the segments of a clan or maximal lineage must be present. Funerals of politico-ritual functionaries such as *t*ndaanas, and the ceremony by which a man takes over the custody of a lineage *b(ə)ar* shrine, are ceremonies of this kind. *Ah(ə)s* of every branch of the clan usually attend such ceremonies. Then they are divided into two groups: *dugni ah(ə)s*, those who are linked through their mother or an ancestress to the inner lineage responsible for the ceremony; and *y*ha *ah(ə)s*, outside *ah(ə)s*, whose mothers or ancestresses came from other segments of the clan.

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The lineage principle operating in relation to the flux of time introduces a new feature. A man dies and in due course his social roles pass  297 to one of his sons. The son now assumes the duties his father had as a mother's brother. He now sacrifices on behalf of his father's sister's sons and becomes their *ah(ə)b* in function. So a mother's brother's son is, in certain situations, called *ah(ə)b* by identification with his father in accordance with the lineage principle, even while his father is still alive—in anticipation, as it were, of the role he will one day have. On the same principle a sister's son's son may be identified with his father in relation to the latter's mother's brother's sons and lineage. Thus (O)mara once introduced a young man from Gorogo to me as his *ah(ə)b*. I expressed surprise, as I knew his mother came from Woo. He then explained that the young man was really his father's *ah(ə)b* (*ba ah(ə)b*)—not, of course, his father's true mother's brother, but the grandson and successor of the latter.

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